Three Places a Medicaid Application Gets Tangled While Mom's Care Goes On

What each one looks like, why it happens, and a steadier habit for each.

A Medicaid application rarely arrives in a quiet month. It lands in the same weeks as the calls from the rehab and the decisions about where Mom goes next. Most families find the paperwork tangles in the same three places. None of them is anyone's fault, and one habit helps with all three.

1 Fitting the application in around everything else

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A statement gets read in the rehab parking lot, a form is half filled in at the kitchen table late at night, and three of you each believe someone else made the call about it.

WHY IT HAPPENS Care decisions have a person attached and can't be put down. Paper can, so it gets whatever time is left. And an application is more than a form: the federal long-term care site says a person has to fill out an application and provide documentation to verify both general and financial requirements. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Give the paperwork one home and one keeper: one box or binder, one person who holds it, and one page on top that says what's in it. The National Institute on Aging's advice is to put important papers in one place and tell someone you trust where to find them. Then divide the questions by who can answer them. The gathering is yours. Which program, where to submit and when to apply go to your Medicaid planner. [2]

2 Keeping the missing records in your head

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “I think there was a life insurance policy.” “The deed is somewhere at the house.” Everyone knows a few things aren't in the folder, and nobody has the list.

WHY IT HAPPENS Mom's papers were kept for Mom, not for an application, so they're spread across drawers, the mail and accounts only she looked at. Some may be on paper and some online: the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's advice to older adults is to keep recent statements available, along with information about how to get them online. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Write the gaps down by name, under the same headings as the records you do have: identity and residency, income, bank accounts, investments and retirement, insurance, real estate, trusts and annuities. Beside each, note where you've looked and who might know. Then ask your Medicaid planner which of them the application needs, and for what dates, before you spend a weekend searching.

3 Tracking the agency's requests from memory

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A letter from the Medicaid agency is opened, read twice and set down with the rest of the mail. A few days on, nobody is sure what it asked for, whether anything went back, or who was going to call.

WHY IT HAPPENS Once an application is in, letters and calls arrive in the middle of everything else, while the care and its bills carry on. The federal long-term care site notes that it may take longer for the state to determine eligibility when required documents aren't provided on time, so it helps to know where each request stands. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Keep one dated log: what was submitted and whatever shows that it went, each letter or call, what was asked for in the letter's own words, any reply date the letter states, and what was sent back. Keep a copy of everything. Don't work out what a notice means or when an answer is due; take the letter to your Medicaid planner, or call the office that sent it, and write down who you spoke with.

The one habit behind all three

One place for the paper, and one page that says what you have, what you haven't found, and what has been sent or asked for. The questions that page raises go to a professional who knows your state.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say when Mom should apply, which records her state asks for or what any letter means, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. It names three places the paperwork tangles, which are the same three the Medicaid Planning Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know the three places the paperwork tends to tangle, and a habit for each. The planning interview builds on what you've written down: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

That applying takes both a form and supporting documents, and that a determination may take longer when documents aren't provided on time, come from the federal long-term care site. The advice about one place for important papers is the National Institute on Aging's, and the advice about statements is the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's. The three tangles are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness

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